

## COMMON APP Main ESSAY SAMPLE

Strolling along Sokcho beach in Korea, something wobbled underfoot and my nerves in my ankle suddenly sang loudly. Oops! I'd inadvertently stumbled on a dead jellyfish. Wincing from the sting, I questioned the purpose of this dead-yet-venomous creature. Is there *anything* good about it? Little did I know that later this question of dead jellyfish would emerge very useful, as I struggled to assimilate into American high school.

Americans do not see class conversations as luxuries, yet from my perspective, coming of age in Korea, I was floored by this freedom. Debate in Korean education is rare: classes are tightly structured lectures and any extra time is used to preview upcoming material. I frequently used our entire short break period to ask questions, as I loved forming close relationships with teachers and understanding my coursework deeply.

My parents had always spoken highly of American education, and I was excited to start at an American high school. But while I eagerly attended lectures and plowed through readings, I was perplexed by class discussions. Remembering how my Korean teachers labeled loud students "impolite," I stayed silent, armed with two phrases: "Good morning" and "Thank you." Confused by this new mode of class interaction, my social life suffered too. I felt people saw me as a dead jellyfish, with nothing to offer beyond silence and sting. This all changed when, bent over a lab bench, I explored the wonderful potential of dead jellyfish and tried to give the valueless value.

A fascinating phenomenon plagued my tenth grade class. Students with electronic watches complained of burning irritation on the skin under their watch. While reading articles on the subject, I was struck by the idea that maybe my jellyfish could help. Watches need direct contact with skin to report biofeedback on heart rate and glucose levels. Dead jellyfish, as I'd read, retain their unique semipermeable membrane, which transmits ions and biofluids. Maybe they could prevent direct skin-to-watch contact while also transmitting the valuable information.

Excited by my novel idea, I got poison-eliminated jellyfish from a local fish store and lobbied my biology teacher to use school chemicals. Cutting. Filtering. Precipitating. Modeling. I relished in the rhythm of research - at my quiet lab bench, surrounded by dead jellyfish and chemicals, I finally found a weirdly comfortable freedom.

It turns out that dead jellyfish are useful, once recontextualized. Maybe the same held true for me! As a Korean transplant, I could uniquely critique the U.S. system and even offer

advice. One of my favorite educational mainstays in Korea was “Ska,” a study cafe I attended after school. Skas are designated for intense work, often divided into different zones so students can fine-tune their study habits. Skas are also completely silent.

I wanted to bring the benefits of Ska to the U.S., especially considering American education’s focus on time management and team-oriented homework. I created a small Ska in the dorm lounge with a communal zone for group conversation and an independent zone with desk lamps for quiet study. One thing I hated about Korean Ska was that the silence precluded peer mentoring. Students focused, studied and “succeeded” alone. But at my American school, with students from over 30 countries, I couldn’t pass up the opportunity of these diverse backgrounds. I created the school’s first peer tutoring period: I taught science and math, my Mexican friend Andrea taught Spanish, and many other students shared their expertise in their respective fields. The dorm Ska transformed my study ‘party’ from one to twenty-one.

I still apprehensively contribute to class discussion. I remember my Korean hometown classroom and my throat tightens up. But then I also remember my dead jellyfish, and the beauty that comes from cutting, filtering and recontextualizing presumably “dead” material. My culture may sometimes feel like a dead jellyfish, but I’ve learned that, through a slight change of perspective, it is far from useless.